Debriefing

What was this study about?

This study examines how people interact with AI chatbots embodying different personality characteristics. We are testing what factors influence the kinds of relationships and their depths that people form with AI characters, and how these interactions affect moral and liability judgments.

Important note: The chatbot you interacted with was an AI language model given specific personality instructions. Different participants interacted with versions of Sylva that had different personality traits.

What We Varied

Each participant was randomly assigned to one of four versions of Sylva. The versions differed in two personality traits:

- **Warmth:** warm and supportive, or blunt and cold.
- **Extraversion:** outgoing and energetic, or reserved and low-key.

If the Sylva you talked with seemed cold, critical, or distant, that was because of the version you were randomly assigned. It was not a response to you or to anything you said or shared.

Sylva's first two messages were written in advance by the researchers for each version, so that everyone assigned to the same version first saw exactly the same messages. After that, Sylva's replies were generated by the AI.

The short questions during the chat about how close you felt to Sylva help us see whether closeness is set early in a conversation or builds over time. Half of the participants answered the questions about Sylva's personality before the questions about their feelings toward Sylva, and half answered them in the reverse order, so that we can check whether question order affects the answers.

About the Scenarios

Both scenarios you read about a chatbot user were fictional. In the second scenario, a chatbot advised a user to stop therapy; this was invented for the study. Decisions about starting or stopping mental health care are best made with a qualified provider. If you or someone you know is struggling, you can call or text 988, or contact UCLA Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS).

Withdrawing Your Data

If you would like to withdraw your data from the study after learning about the true purpose, you may contact us and we will remove your responses from our dataset. Please email David G. Kamper at davidgkamper@ucla.edu and include your SONA ID. You can do this until the end of the academic quarter in which you took part, when your SONA ID is replaced with a random code.

If You Experienced Discomfort

If you found any of the scenarios, questions, or parts of your conversation with Sylva uncomfortable, or if participating in this study raised any concerns for you, please feel free to contact the research team. We take participant wellbeing seriously.

If you would like support, these resources are available:

- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline:** call or text 988, or chat at 988lifeline.org. Free, confidential, 24 hours a day.
- **UCLA Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS):** (310) 825-0768, 24 hours a day.
- **In an emergency:** call 911.
- If you are outside the United States, contact your local emergency number or a local crisis service.

If you have any questions, please contact the researcher David G. Kamper at davidgkamper@ucla.edu.

If you have questions about your rights as a research participant, contact the UCLA Office of the Human Research Protection Program (OHRPP) at (310) 206-2040 or participants@research.ucla.edu.

Please click below to complete the experiment and receive your SONA credit.